



Frenchtown Sun

A Frenchtown-Focused Civic Newsletter

Frenchtown Halloween Activities Return with Witches, Zombies & Parade

Frenchtown is kicking off its annual Halloween festivities on Saturday, October 24 with the Halloween Parade, followed by the Witches Dance and Zombie Crawl on Sunday, October 25.

Parade registration is 12 – 4 p.m. on the 24th at the Frenchtown American Legion, the parade lineup starts at 4 p.m. Harrison Street will be closed to car traffic by 4:50 p.m. and the parade will officially begin at 5:00 p.m. Harrison Street will reopen when the parade concludes.

The Frenchtown American Legion is excited to announce a new parade category this year: a pet division. Owners can dress up their pets to impress judges, take home prizes and enjoy some treats.

Frenchtown will also host its annual Witches Dance and Zombie Crawl in Sunbeam Park on Sunday, October 25. The Witches Dance is open to all community members willing to bust a move. The dance will start at 11 a.m. Participants are encouraged to bring their own brooms and costumes for the performance. *[Continued on page 5]*



Photographer: Paul Serra

Voting: What Residents Need to Know Ahead of November 3 Election Day

As residents prepare for the upcoming statewide General Election on Tuesday, November 3, they have several options on how to submit their vote: residents can cast their ballots by mail, take advantage of early in-person voting or head to the polls on Election Day. The Hunterdon County website provides a simple guide to voting at: <https://www.co.hunterdon.nj.us/970/Election-Voter-Information>.

KEY VOTING DATES & DEADLINES:

- Voter registration deadline: new residents registering to vote or those needing to update their voter registration details must do so on or before Tuesday, October 13. Forms to register for voting in New Jersey can be found at the link above. It is

important to note that these forms must be received by the October 13 deadline.

- Vote-by-mail: The deadline to apply for a mail-in ballot is Tuesday, October 27. Instructions on how to request a vote-by-mail ballot can be found on the county Board of Elections website at: <https://www.co.hunterdon.nj.us/2639/Requesting-A-Vote-By-Mail>. Vote-by-mail ballots can be returned using the post office (no postage is necessary) and must be mailed at least 7 days before Election Day. Vote-by-mail ballots can also be dropped off at any of the 12 drop boxes located throughout the county or returned in person by 3 p.m. on November 2 to the Board of Elections office located at 112 Broad St., Flemington; a list of the drop *[Continued on page 7]*

About *The Frenchtown Sun*

The Frenchtown Sun is published monthly by the Borough of Frenchtown to provide its residents with local news and community updates.

The content of *The Sun* is guided by the editorial team of Ted Brandston, Randi Eckel, Rick Epstein, John Gattuso, Jeanne Herb, Amelia Rodriguez and Maria Whelan. John Dougherty serves as the Borough Council liaison.

The Sun is delivered monthly free of charge to all Frenchtown Borough residents. An online edition is available at www.frenchtownsun.net.

Borough residents can request postal delivery or contact the editorial team at newsletter@frenchtownboro.com or mail *The Frenchtown Sun*, 29 Second Street, Frenchtown, N.J. 08825.

Updates from Borough Council

At its monthly meeting on September 2, Borough Council:

- heard a public statement from Delaware Valley Regional High School (DVRHS) Board of Education representative Tom Loughlin about the referendum that will appear on November 3's election ballot. The referendum is for a new fire alarm system at DVRHS. The current system is 20 years old and needs replacing. Since the previous installation, the fire code has changed. The replacement system must meet the new state requirements, including adding strobes and speakers in each of the spaces throughout the building. Voter approval of the referendum allows the district to qualify for 34% state debt-service aid on eligible project costs, reducing the district's share of the total project cost from the estimated and approved eligible cost of \$926,000 to \$611,160; this includes costs for equipment, installation, architectural/engineering fees and permits. If the final costs come in below the estimated cost, excess bond proceeds can be used to pay the bond, reducing the district's local share further. The system is going to be paid for out of DVRHS's reserve funds and will not raise taxes. All registered voters in Frenchtown can vote on the referendum. To learn more about the referendum, visit: <https://www.dvrhs.org/page/bond-referendum-project-details>. To read DVRHS Superintendent Scott McKinney's letter to the community on the referendum, visit: frenchtownsun.net/2026-oct-delval-letter.pdf.

- extended its authorization to establish and continue the operations of *The Frenchtown Sun* as an entity of the borough.

- introduced a capital ordinance providing various improvements to Borough Hall, appropriating \$250,000; \$50,000 from the borough's capital improvement fund and \$200,000 from a grant from the state.

- introduced a land use ordinance for exceptions, modifications and supplementary regulations of the borough code to establish exceptions for permanent wheelchair ramps, first floor bathrooms and medically necessary equipment for residents with mobility limitations and health conditions. The ordinance is a direct outcome of the borough's adoption of an Age-Friendly Action Plan that can be found at:

<https://frenchtownboro.com/community-services/age-friendly-frenchtown>.

- the Planning/Zoning Board recommended two new land use ordinances to Council for their consideration. One ordinance provides standards for the installation of roof-mounted solar panels, which are already permitted as an accessory use throughout the borough. The second recommended ordinance would prohibit data centers anywhere in the borough. Similar data center ordinances have been adopted by nearby municipalities (including the borough of Milford, Holland, Alexandria and Kingwood townships) and others across the state. In both cases, the Planning Board's recommendations follow the advice of the borough master plan and borough planner Darlene Green, who shared more information about these potential ordinances at the meeting, sharing the goals of encouraging the efficient use of energy and the use of renewable energy sources while also preserving the natural, scenic, historic and aesthetic aspects of the community and its environment. The Council will discuss these ordinances [*Continued on page 6*]

Spotlight on the Frenchtown Public Library

For more than a century, Frenchtown's public library has quietly served as one of the borough's most beloved civic anchors. Like many municipal libraries in Hunterdon County, early efforts to establish a public reading room in Frenchtown relied on volunteers and donations from local civic groups and residents. Throughout the early 20th century, community members rallied to secure a dedicated shelf space for shared books, and organized book drives and small-scale fundraising events.

As the collection grew during the mid-20th century, the library moved through several locations in town, including dedicated storefronts. In 1938, the library secured a stable home on Second St. (initially operating out of 27 Second St. before establishing its permanent home next door at 29 Second St.).

The library is an affiliate, but not a branch, of the Hunterdon County Library system. In fact, the only two libraries in the county that are branches of the main library on Rt. 12 in Flemington are the North County Branch in Clinton and the South County Branch in East Amwell. The Frenchtown library operates independently from the county library with the borough supporting the salary of library staff as well as owning the building in which the library resides; a 2022 grant to the Borough supported repairs to the library interior. The Frenchtown library maintains its own collection while providing patrons access to county-wide resources, interlibrary loans and shared catalog systems through which residents can request books from the county library be delivered to the Frenchtown library.

As a member of the Main Library Alliance—a network encompassing dozens of public libraries across Hunterdon, Morris, Somerset, Union and Warren counties—the Frenchtown library offers local readers access to hundreds of thousands of physical books, audiobooks, digital downloads, e-books and research databases with a single library card.

To learn more about the library, visit the website which is hosted on the borough's main website:

<https://frenchtownboro.com/library/>.

Library hours are:

- Monday: 3:30 – 7 p.m.
- Tuesday: 3:30 – 7 p.m.
- Wednesday: 9:30 a.m. – 1 p.m.
- Thursday: 9:30 a.m. – 1 p.m.
- Closed on Friday, Saturday and Sunday

Tree Removal Regulations to Know

Our area has seen its share of storm damage, as it does every year, and fall is when many folks do tree maintenance to remove dead, dying or damaged tree branches and trees.

The public right-of-way for shade trees generally refers to the planting strip or strip of ground located adjacent to the street or between the street and the sidewalk. The Frenchtown Shade Tree Commission is responsible for planting, trimming, care, and removal of trees within these public right-of-way areas. Residents are expected to apply to the Shade Tree Commission—call the Borough Clerk for more information—before removing a street tree located in the public right-of-way, unless the tree is immediately hazardous.

For non-street trees, the Tree Removal and Replacement Ordinance that was adopted by Council in 2024 applies (24-919, now section 50-311 of the Borough Land Use Ordinance). In 2024, every municipality in the state was required to adopt a Tree Removal and Replacement Ordinance based on environmental frameworks established by the New Jersey Department of Environmental Protection (NJDEP) to preserve mature trees, whenever possible, throughout the state of New Jersey and, when preservation is not possible, to replace them. The borough ordinance specifically applies to the removal of any large non-street tree—that is, any tree with a diameter at breast height (DBH) of six inches or more. In most cases, to remove a large tree, residents must fill out and submit a tree removal application to the borough clerk. The ordinance also spells out replacement requirements—these detail which species of tree can be planted as approved replacement trees, how large the replacement trees must be, as well as how many trees must be planted to replace each removed large tree (that number being based on the size of the removed tree). It is important to note, however, that hazardous trees (including dead or dying trees) and invasive tree species are exempt from this ordinance. For more details and information, the full ordinance can be found here:

<https://ecode360.com/47941029#47941029>.

—Randi Eckel

Community Calendar

TUESDAY, OCTOBER 6

Super Seniors, 11 a.m. – 1:30 p.m., Presbyterian Church, 22 Fourth St., *Free for adults over 55; yoga with Priscilla, lunch and lecture on new rules for fall clean up by Master Gardeners*

WEDNESDAY, OCTOBER 7

- **Borough Council Meeting, 7 p.m.,** Borough Hall, 29 Second St.
- **Clam Night at the American Legion, 5 p.m.,** 510 Harrison St.

THURSDAY, OCTOBER 8

- **Hunterdon County's 3rd Annual Veterans Resource Fair, 11 a.m. – 3 p.m.,** Razberry's Banquet Hall, 834 State Rt. 12, *Free event; featuring local vendors showcasing their products and services tailored to veterans; for more information call 908-788-1102 or email veterans@co.hunterdon.nj.us.*
- **Shade Tree Commission Meeting, 4:30 p.m.,** Borough Hall, 29 Second St.

SATURDAY, OCTOBER 10

- **Rivertown Bridges "Free for All" Community-Wide Free Stuff Giveaway Day, 9 a.m. – 5 p.m.,** *Expanding on the success of Buy Nothing "Booty in the Boot" gifting events, Rivertown Bridges encourages residents to set up their "sale" at their individual home, but rather than items being for sale, all items are being given away for free! This event offers a wonderful opportunity to declutter your home and to pass along items that no longer serve you—or to find some new treasures for free. A great way to keep things out of landfills and an opportunity to connect with your neighbors! Please visit www.rivertownbridges.org to sign-up to be included in the "Free for All".*
- **Lions Club Coin Toss, 11 a.m.,** Race St. and Bridge St., *Rain date: Sunday, October 11, 11 a.m.*

TUESDAY, OCTOBER 13

- **Frenchtown Board of Education Meeting, 6:45 p.m.,** Frenchtown School, 902 Harrison St.
- **Environmental Commission Meeting, 7 p.m.,** Borough Hall, 29 Second St.

THURSDAY, OCTOBER 15

Rivertown Bridges Community Potluck & Storytelling, 6:30 p.m., Presbyterian Church, 22 Fourth St., *All are welcome at the community potluck! If*

you would like to attend, please RSVP to info@rivertownbridges.org. Please bring a dish to share, a main, side, salad or dessert for 5-6 people. Attendees are encouraged to bring their own beverages, dishware, and utensils.

SATURDAY, OCTOBER 17

Townwide Clean-up Day

SUNDAY, OCTOBER 18

Breakfast at Darcy Lodge, 8 – 11 a.m., 39 Everittstown Rd., *\$12 per person ages 13+, \$7 per person ages 6-12, children under 5 eat free; all-you-can-eat buffet.*

TUESDAY, OCTOBER 20

Super Seniors, 11 a.m. – 1:30 p.m., Presbyterian Church, 22 Fourth St., *Free for adults over 55; yoga with Priscilla, lunch and lecture on Colonial Kitchen by Master Gardeners*

WEDNESDAY, OCTOBER 21

Clam Night at the American Legion, 5 p.m., 510 Harrison St.

SATURDAY, OCTOBER 24

- **Frenchtown Farmers Market, 10 a.m. – 2 p.m.,** Sunbeam Lenape Park
- **Halloween Parade, 5 p.m.,** American Legion, 510 Harrison St., *Registration for parade is 12 – 4 p.m., line-up begins at 4 p.m. and parade kicks off at 5 p.m. (learn more on page 1)*

SUNDAY, OCTOBER 25

- **Frenchtown Witches Dance, 11:30 a.m. – 1 p.m.,** Sunbeam Lenape Park, *Wear your finest witchy attire and BYOB (bring your own broom!); witches gather at 11:30 a.m., dance lesson at 12 p.m., final performance 1 p.m., witches walk through town 1:30 p.m.; please consider bringing food donations for the FPC Community Pantry (learn more on page 1)*
- **Zombie Crawl, 11 a.m. – 7 p.m.,** Sunbeam Lenape Park, *Get "zombified" by local makeup artists from 2 – 4:30 p.m.; "fresh bite" (basic makeup) for \$5, "totally rotten" (add-on prosthetics) for \$15; the Zombie Crawl will begin at 5 p.m.; scavenger hunt and trophies for costume contest; Rain date: Sunday, October 25, 11 a.m. (learn more on page 1)]*

WEDNESDAY, OCTOBER 28

Planning/Zoning Board Meeting, 7 p.m., Borough Hall, 29 Second St.

Save the Date: Frenchtown Mayor's Age-friendly Town Hall on November 7

Mayor Brad Myhre and members of Borough Council will host a town hall meeting on topics related to Frenchtown's age-friendly initiative. The town hall will take place on Saturday, November 7 from 10 a.m. – 12 p.m. at the Frenchtown Elementary School. The Mayor will update residents on age-friendly activities underway throughout the borough and hear from older residents about their needs and priorities to live safe, healthy and vibrant lives in the borough.

The first hour will focus on a conversation with the Mayor and Council members and the second hour will serve as a resource and service provider "open house." Various organizations and agencies that serve older residents have been invited to participate so that residents can become more familiar with services and programs that are available to them.

Older residents who may need assistance getting to the Frenchtown Elementary School should contact the Borough Clerk at clerk@frenchtownboro.com or call 908-996-4524 and a volunteer will reach out to offer assistance.

News from the County Senior Center

The Hunterdon County Senior Center will be hosting a variety of programs in October that are free and open to the public. For more information on programs listed below and for general information on the Senior Center, residents can visit <https://www.co.hunterdon.nj.us/495/Senior-Center> or call 908-788-1359.

Membership to the Senior Center is free; you must be a resident of Hunterdon County and 60 years of age.

Upcoming October programs include:

- A new hybrid strength and balance fitness program designed to help older adults stay independent and active called VIVO, offered by VIVO's certified trainers. VIVO offers four levels of every exercise, from seated to advanced, that can be done in person or virtually on Zoom. For more information, visit:

<https://www.co.hunterdon.nj.us/DocumentCenter/View/20602/Vivo-Steady-and-Strong-Class>.

- Ballroom dancing classes are now available, thanks to funding from the Creative Aging Initiative Grant through the Cultural and Heritage

Commission. For more information, visit:

<https://www.co.hunterdon.nj.us/DocumentCenter/View/20591/Ballroom-Dance-Classes-1020>.

- Hunterdon County Clerk Mary Melfi will visit the Senior Center to provide information on elections, deed frauds, passport cards and ident-a-shred and answer any questions residents may have. For more information, visit:

<https://www.co.hunterdon.nj.us/DocumentCenter/View/20595/Coffee-With-County-Clerk-101>.

- A new monthly support group for seniors who are estranged from their adult children will start in October. For more information, visit: <https://www.co.hunterdon.nj.us/DocumentCenter/View/20600/Senior-Estrangement>.

- Tech Round Table discussions with information on various tech topics will resume after a summer hiatus. The onsite Tech Help Desk is open on Mondays and Thursdays, from 1 – 2:30 p.m. Call 908-788-1359 to make your appointment.

- In addition to the Center's regularly scheduled fitness and social recreational programs and classes, there will be a talk and re-enactment of Charles Lindbergh's historic flight as well as a talk on Hannah Caldwell from June 1780. To learn more, visit the two following websites, respectively: <https://www.co.hunterdon.nj.us/DocumentCenter/View/20594/Charles-Lindbergh-101526> and <https://www.co.hunterdon.nj.us/DocumentCenter/View/20597/Ghost-of-Hannah-Caldwell-101626>.

Frenchtown: A Best Arts & Culture Town

The travel magazine *Travel + Leisure* listed Frenchtown as one of "America's Best Small Towns". Featuring places to stay, dine and visit in town, *Travel + Leisure* shared why visitors would find Frenchtown the perfect "riverside retreat". Read more here: frenchtownsun.net/r/t-and-l-26.

Halloween Festivities This Month

[Continued from page 1] Lead witches will guide dancers through the routine, culminating with a final performance at 1 p.m.

The Zombie Crawl will take place at 2 p.m. A "zombification" station will be available in Sunbeam Park; local makeup artists will be offering prosthetic looks. The zombies will take over Frenchtown's sidewalks at 5:00 p.m.

To learn more, visit: lovefrenchtown.org/zombie.

—Amelia Rodriguez

Frenchtown Elementary School BOE Sets 2026-2027 Board & District Goals

At the August FES Board of Education meeting, members Adam Blackburn, Michael Dermody, Rachel Howard, Julie Klein, Erinn Nakahara, Veda Partalo and Kate Nugent set their goals for school year 2026-2027. The district goals are:

1. Provide a foundation for later success in education and life by ensuring facilities, resources, environments and opportunities for all students to unlock their highest academic and creative potential. By June 2027, at least 80% of students will demonstrate measurable growth in two or more academic indicators as compared to baseline assessments through the implementation of high-quality instruction, targeted interventions and data-driven decision making.

2. Increase student awareness of future educational, career and community opportunities by developing and implementing initiatives that broaden student perspectives, with a particular focus on broadening middle school students' academic and cultural perspectives while intentionally developing character skills such as empathy, respect, responsibility and conscientiousness.

3. By December 31, 2026, develop a comprehensive survey of students, staff and community members, to understand the strengths and areas that need improvement, to be conducted by February 28, 2027. When available, the survey will be circulated to parents and located on the school website.

The board's goals are as follows:

1. Build a strong and representative board by making opportunities for board service accessible, transparent and open to interested community members and develop a process for orientation and continuing education of board members.

2. Create a feasible, community-informed plan for renovating the auditorium and determine appropriate funding options for moving forward.

3. Increase FES participation in community events including town government meetings, townwide events and parades.

4. By spring 2027, review and revise district policy to establish clear, age-appropriate guidelines for student screen use across the district based on the informed participation of FES staff, board and community members, as well as a review of current evidence regarding developmental and educational impact of screens on young learners.

Frenchtown Elementary Welcomes its Centennial Kindergarten Class!



As Frenchtown Elementary School celebrates its historic 1926–2026 centennial year, its halls are once again filled with bright eyes, brand-new backpacks and boundless potential.

This September, FES proudly welcomed the class of 2039—a vibrant kindergarten group that brings together twelve enthusiastic young learners. The incoming kindergartners reflect the strong roots of Frenchtown's local community, joining from a variety of early childhood backgrounds. Most of the 12 students are transitioning from the Frenchtown Elementary Preschool Program, with the remaining students joining from other local early learning programs, including Secret Garden Montessori, just three blocks away from FES. About half of the new kindergarten class has a parent, grandparent, or great-grandparent who attended FES.

In kindergarten, students enjoy many wonderful stories, play number games, draw pictures, sing songs, write stories and create artwork. From learning foundational reading and math skills to being introduced to foreign languages to building lifelong friendships on the playground, these young scholars are embarking on an unforgettable journey.

Please join the entire Frenchtown community in extending a warm welcome to the new kindergarten class and their families!

Borough Council Updates from Sept.

[Continued from page 2] further in October.

- acknowledged that the Frenchtown Fire Department was awarded a \$12,000 grant for portable radios.

Enjoy Fall Colors and Leave the Leaves!



Actias luna, or the luna moth

Local trees are turning glorious colors. In our area, peak fall color usually arrives in mid-to-late October—just in time for Halloween. Some of our most notable trees for fall color include maples (turning shades of red and yellow), sweetgums (yellow/red/purple), tulip poplars (bright yellow), birches (yellow), sycamores (dull yellow) and dogwoods (red/orange/yellow)—the list goes on and on. Some years, even northern red oaks (and other oaks) put on a show with wonderful shades of deep red—in 2025 they were particularly impressive.

But why do leaves turn color in fall? These colors have been in the leaves all season long; the green that we see in leaves is due to chlorophyll which is what plants use to capture the energy of the sun. The shorter days, less intense sunlight, and cooler temperatures of autumn cause the chlorophyll in deciduous tree leaves to break down, removing the green 'mask' and allowing the underlying colors to suddenly appear.

By Thanksgiving, almost all of the leaves will have fallen—but notably not the leaves of oaks, beech, ironwoods and a few other species that have what are called 'marcescent leaves'. These trees hold on to their leaves throughout most of the winter, making them easy to pick out in the landscape. It is thought that marcescence evolved to protect winter twigs from being browsed by ancient herbivores that used to roam North America such as giant sloths (and it seems to help a bit with modern white-tailed deer as well).

But even as leaves fall to the ground, their ecological job is not done. In recent years, most gardeners have become acutely aware of the import-

ance of 'leaving the leaves'. Not only do fallen leaves break down over time returning nutrients to the soil, provide natural mulch which retains soil moisture and slows erosion, and supplies critical habitat and shelter for overwintering wildlife including butterflies, salamanders and other creatures. Some of our most glorious native moths, such as luna moths and giant silk moths, overwinter in cocoons that they have spun in dead leaves which then drop to the ground where they hide (perfectly camouflaged) and bide their time until spring when they will emerge and fly again. —Randi Eckel

How and Where to Get Out the Vote

[Continued from page 1] box locations can be found at: <https://www.co.hunterdon.nj.us/1130/Polling-Places-Ballot-Box-Locations>.

- The period for early in-person voting is Saturday, October 24 – Sunday, November 1. Registered voters can cast a ballot at designated early voting centers across Hunterdon County. Locations for early voting can be found at the polling places and ballot box locations in the link listed above.
- In person voting on Election Day: residents can vote at Borough Hall (29 Second St., Frenchtown) between the hours of 6 a.m. – 8 p.m.

WHAT'S ON THE BALLOT:

The list of candidates in the General Election can be found on the Hunterdon County website:

<https://www.co.hunterdon.nj.us/2949/2026-General-Ballot-Candidates>.

There is a bond referendum on the ballot to replace the DVRHS's fire alarm system; more information on the referendum is provided by the DVRHS Board of Education:

<https://www.dvrhs.org/page/2026-referendum> (see also "Updates from Borough Council" story on page 2).

For additional voter information, sample ballots, or voter registration status, visit:

<https://www.co.hunterdon.nj.us/1409/2026-Voter-Information>.

Frenchtown's Oldest Running Business

Standing prominently on Kingwood Avenue, Frenchtown Home and Hardware is the borough's oldest continuously operating retail tradition. The store's journey reflects the changing character of the borough across three centuries.

In 1884 George W. Eddy and his son Samuel purchased an existing hardware business housed in the three-story "Eddy Block" at [Continued on page 8]

Helping Make Frenchtown Home: The Generations Behind Frenchtown's Oldest Store

[Continued from page 7] 34–40 Bridge Street. In an era when Delaware River traffic, the canal and the Belvidere Delaware Railroad powered local commerce, Eddy's store supplied residents with homestead tools, agricultural supplies and heavy building materials.

The Eddy family operated the business through four generations. In 1962, William "Bill" Eddy downsized and relocated the store to 47 Bridge Street. Bill ended the 96-year family dynasty in 1980 when he sold the business to Howard "Gene" Hale who is remembered by locals as a "true gem" who could help fix almost anything.

Renaming the store "Frenchtown Home & Hardware," Hale moved the store in 1983 to 11 King-

wood Avenue—originally E.B. Apgar's auto-repair garage. Hale adapted the inventory while preserving the tradition of old-fashioned personal service.

In 2012, Hale handed the reins to Mike Tyksinski. Modernized to serve today's homeowners, tradespeople and DIYers, the store remains rooted in the community spirit established by the Eddys and preserved by Hale. In an era dominated by big-box stores and online retail, Frenchtown Home and Hardware remains a rare local treasure. Besides serving the Frenchtown community through the store's retail operations, Tyksinski is active in the Frenchtown Professional and Business Association and supporting the local arts community.



*From left to right:
Bill and Vivian
Eddy, Gene Hale
and Mike Tyksinski.
Photos and history
courtesy of Rick
Epstein, Mike
Tysinski and the
Hale family*

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